

Title DE Uncovering RT Deutsch's Content-Laundering Ecosystem

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Summary

- Multiple websites automatically repost RT Deutsch content, helping Russian state media remain visible to German-speaking audiences despite official bans and restrictions.
- These aggregator and mirror sites frequently utilize RSS feeds and other automated tools to syndicate RT Deutsch's articles, often labeling them only as "news."
- The ecosystem includes at least four "pravda" domains and more than ten aggregator domains, exposing users to RT Deutsch material without redirecting them to RT's blocked domain.
- The technique reflects DISARM TTPs of bypassing content blocks, exploiting search engine results, and distributing Russian state narratives more widely.
- Recommendations: Coordinate with hosting providers and EU regulators, investigate the ownership of mirror domains, and ensure users are informed that these outlets are Russian state-controlled.

Incident

Since at least early 2024, dozens of aggregator or reposter sites have emerged or expanded their operations, automatically reposting or republishing RT Deutsch articles to reach German-speaking audiences. These sites appear to operate without oversight, allowing RT Deutsch's content to circumvent bans and appear in online searches. This allows RT Deutsch's content to maintain a foothold in Germany's media environment, influencing narratives around the Ukraine war and the country's geopolitical alignment.

Narrative

Meta narrative: Degradation of Western institutions;

Sub-narratives: German authorities are stifling dissent through censorship; Germany's support for Ukraine undermines its own national interests; The United States imposes its agenda on European partners.

Impact

- Aggregator and mirror sites, though often low-traffic, still rank in search results and can redirect users to pro-Kremlin narratives.
- The "pravda" (AKA Portal Kombat) domains and similar networks blur lines between legitimate news aggregation and deliberate amplification of sanctioned media.
- Collective monthly traffic for the identified domains may reach several million visitors globally, creating consistent exposure to RT Deutsch content.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework).

Objective: Facilitate State Propaganda - Sustain and expand RT Deutsch's audience in Germany despite legal restrictions.

- Leverage Existing Inauthentic News Sites - Exploit Aggregators: Automated reposting on multiple domains boosts visibility by flooding search engines with RT Deutsch links.
- Remove Post Origins - Certain domains obscure RT Deutsch's authorship, making it more difficult for casual users to identify the content's origin.
- Bypass Content Blocking - Automated reposting on multiple domains boosts visibility by flooding search engines with RT Deutsch links.

Recommendations and Actions Taken (end each recommendation with a ;)

Recommendations: Increase transparency requirements for aggregator sites, mandating clear labeling of content sourced from state-controlled media; Encourage German authorities and EU stakeholders to share information, enhancing detection of emerging mirror domains and content-laundering patterns;

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	Logo
Link	Russia, Election, Content Laundering	Upon request	Larissa Doroshenko, Peter Benzoni, Bret Schafer, GMF ASD.	VK, Telegram, X, Rumble, Odysee, Various Aggregator Sites	